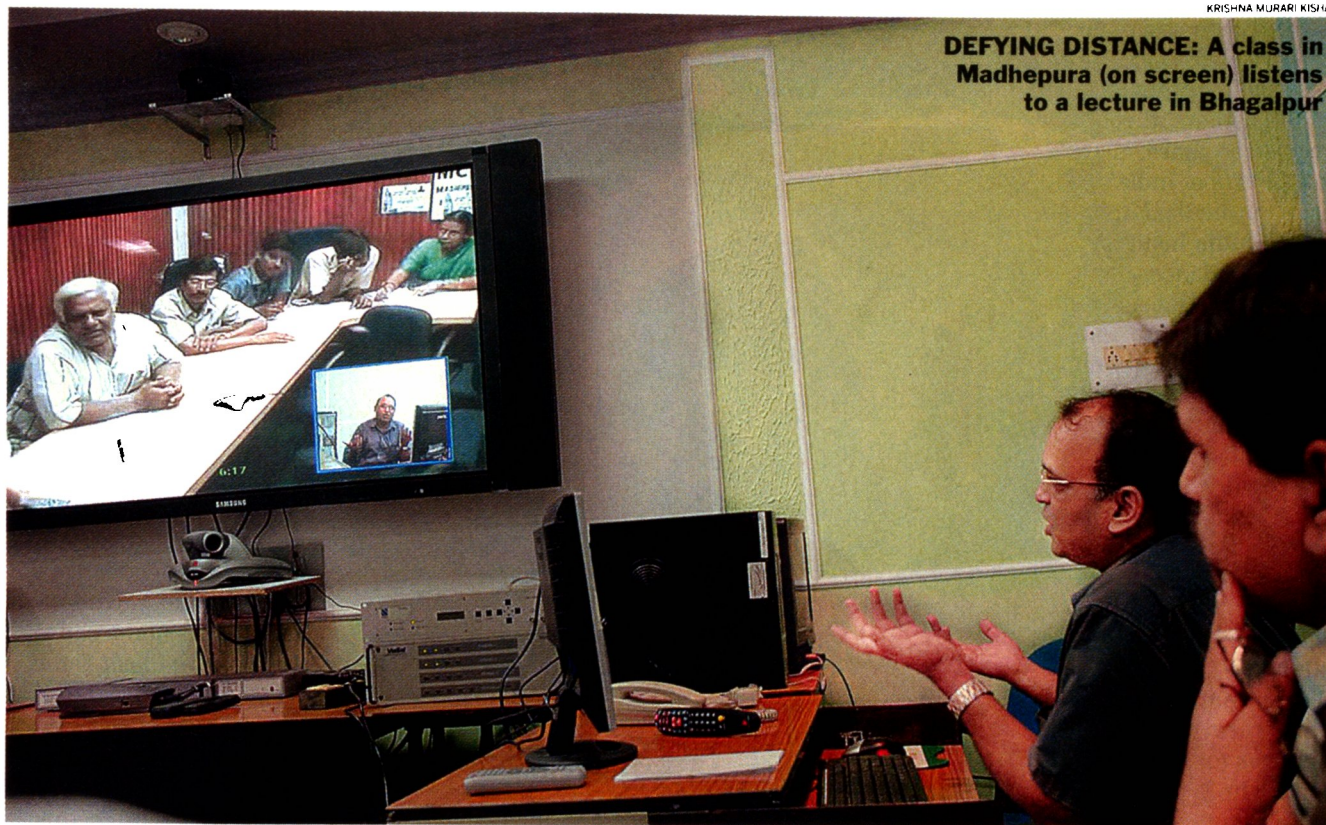




**DEFYING DISTANCE:** A class in Madhepura (on screen) listens to a lecture in Bhagalpur

# Real Knowledge, Virtual Class

**Students of Bihar's silicon campus 'attend' lectures held all over the state—without leaving home**

■ **By Amitabh Srivastava**

**T**he air-conditioned, plush NIC conference room is just too good to look like a typical classroom to Sudhir Kumar, the 19-year-old from Madhepura district in Bihar. The room is spacious, the chairs comfortable and the huge screen inside the hall is flickering, as Prof. A.K. Mishra from the Department of Statistics, Bhagalpur University, more than a hundred kms from Sudhir's home, is lecturing on the "essentials of Database Management." There is a round of questions after the session where the professor answers even the most basic of questions. Queries are also taken through email or scribbled notes, which are scanned and transmitted to the moderator. The highly interactive distance learning sessions may, at times, surpass the interactivity of a traditional classroom.

The lectures are saved electronically so that they can be accessed through the Internet later. The only de-motivator at the virtual classroom is the speak-in-English rule. But initial hesitation has evaporated as students pick up the language and with it, confidence. Sudhir and his fellow students are indeed basking in the glory of being a part of Bihar's silicon campus—the first of its kind in the country—courtesy the National Informatics Centre (NIC) of the Ministry of Communications.

The unique educational programme—Vidya Sagar,



shaped by NIC has linked eight Bihar universities. Every Saturday, the one free day, when NIC studios are not used by the administration, each university holds a session on five different subjects which are open to teachers and scholars of other state universities. Currently, the districts of Patna, Gaya, Bhojpur, Saran, Muzaffarpur, Darbhanga, Madhepura and Bhagalpur are covered by the project.

Saurabh Gupta, senior technical director and state informatics officer of Bihar, says: "Many teachers are excellent in their fields but students of other universities are not able to gain from their knowledge. We, therefore, decided to remove geographical barriers by using our video-conferencing network." At the inauguration, says co-ordinator Bijay Kumar, Patna University faculty delivered lectures at the NIC Patna studio with teachers and students from other universities listening in from their NIC centres. The NIC has petitioned the government to replicate the project in other universities.

Vidya Sagar, based on the concept of triple Cs—communication, collaboration and computer skills, was launched in September and has been a big hit with both students as well as teachers. Often there is a standing room only for some lectures, most of those standing being students. As Prof. Mishra puts it, "Satisfied would be a huge understatement. I am exhilarated."